

Chalicotherium

Chalicotherium was a bizarre hoofed mammal that looked like a cross between a horse and a gorilla. Its front hooves had evolved into massive, hooklike claws, which it probably used to pull branches down from trees so it could reach the leaves. When not on the move, *Chalicotherium* sat on its haunches feeding. It may also have been able to rear up on its hind legs to reach the highest branches. Its odd-toed feet show that it was a distant relative of horses and rhinos.

Chalicotherium

CHA-lih-co-THEE-ree-um



- **When** 15–5 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Asia, Africa
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 6½ ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Plants

Taller than a grizzly bear, this animal had a horselike head, long, clawed forelimbs, and stout hind legs that bore its immense body weight. When fossils of its claws were first discovered, scientists thought it was a type of carnivore. Further research showed it was actually a plant-eating mammal that first appeared during the Neogene Period, 15 million years ago.

